



beginning to appear and I can see the clouds in waiting—just as curtains and backdrops wait for a rock star to make an appearance. We have time yet. So here I am, thinking about what it will take to be a great professional in the days to come.

These days, even a small-town guy who owns a so-called “photo studio” has a digital SLR. I, waiting for the sun, wonder: what is the difference between him and professionals such as Dewitt Jones or Raghu Rai? Since everyone can take great pictures these days, photo-shop them, and freely upload on the Internet, what separates them from these two?

The sunrise is still another good 10 minutes away. Lens yawns listlessly.

His mind does not wander like mine.

Ignoring him, I ask myself, is this question any less relevant for doctors, architects, software engineers, lawyers and dress designers? What is required to be called a professional in the future?

Lens looks at me, rolls his eyes and makes a face, very similar to an affectionately irreverent teenager.

Just then, on cue from the clouds, my body tenses—the Moment has arrived. I lift the camera, pick Lens up, and fix him in. He is sharp and engaged, ready for war. The sliver of red appearing from below has made me one with Lens and my camera. Silently, so as not to disturb the arrival, we begin clicking. A whirr, the sound of a click and the shutter closes. Soft like my breath. Then a small wait. Shoot. Wait. Shoot.

Soon it is a ballet. The initial stiffness of a preying leopard is gone. We are talking again. But this time, Lens is doing most of the talking. I think he is showing off a bit, but he clearly knows what the professional of the future is all about.

“Have you heard of Howard Gardner?” he asks, casually.

I reply, “Oh yes, the Harvard professor who has written 20 books and received 21 honorary doctorates; the same man who questioned the role of IQ in determining intelligence. In fact, it was he who had propagated the idea of multiple intelligence.”

“Same man,” says Lens. He begins to refer to what Gardner had said about professionals of the future: that to be a great professional you have to master the five minds of the future.

“What about that?” I ask a little impatiently, more keen that we focus on the job at hand, concerned that it seems to be suddenly slipping away.

“Why, it was you who asked for the reason your country cousin of a studio photographer could not become Dewitt Jones.”

I can sense that Lens is miffed.

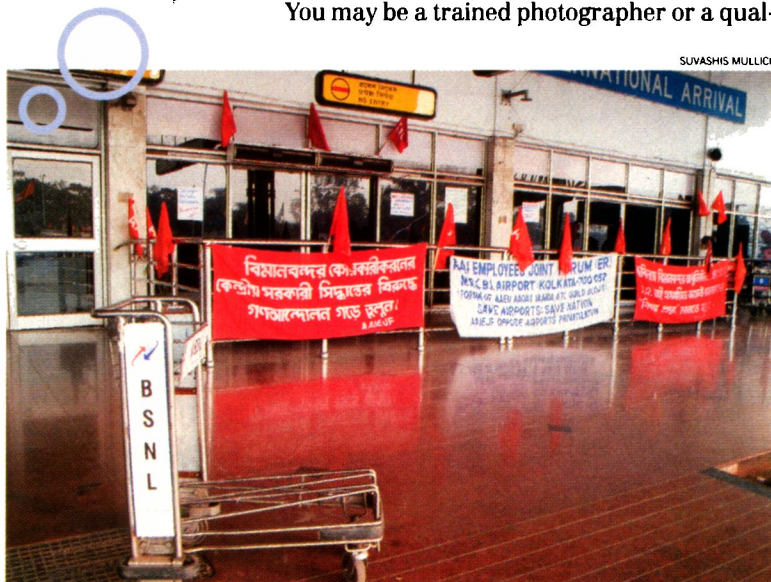
Whirr, click, shoot. Silence. Whirr, click, blink, shoot, silence. More silence. More shots.

Now the sun is fully up, the whole world awash—as if it wasn’t ever dark here. Our job is over. Both of us are calm but still contemplating what has just happened. Then Lens begins explaining the five minds for the future as we start walking back. “Whatever may be your profession, to succeed in the world ahead, you need to master the five minds of the future...”

“The first is the mind of the discipline. You may be a trained photographer or a qual-

25%

OF THE WORLD'S TOTAL
SKILLED WORK FORCE WILL
BE INDIANS BY 2020. INDIA
IS INVESTING RS 2,75,000
CRORE TO CREATE
50 CRORE TRAINED
WORK FORCE BY
2020.



SUVASHIS MULLICK

No discipline: The Kolkata airport wears a deserted look following a strike by workers

ified surgeon. It does not matter. Your professional qualification is not what will make you a professional. You need to devote yourself to your profession of choice for at least 10 years before you can understand its nuances. Empirical studies indicate that, across disciplines, amount of time is a minimum requirement. You have to give yourself to the profession as against looking at it just as a means to a livelihood, a career or a job. You need to build affection for your profession and a long view of time.

The second is the mind of synthesis. The future requires the capacity to build abstractions. In other words, you need the mind of synthesis. It is about developing an understanding of ideas, concepts and problems in an interdisciplinary manner while building depth